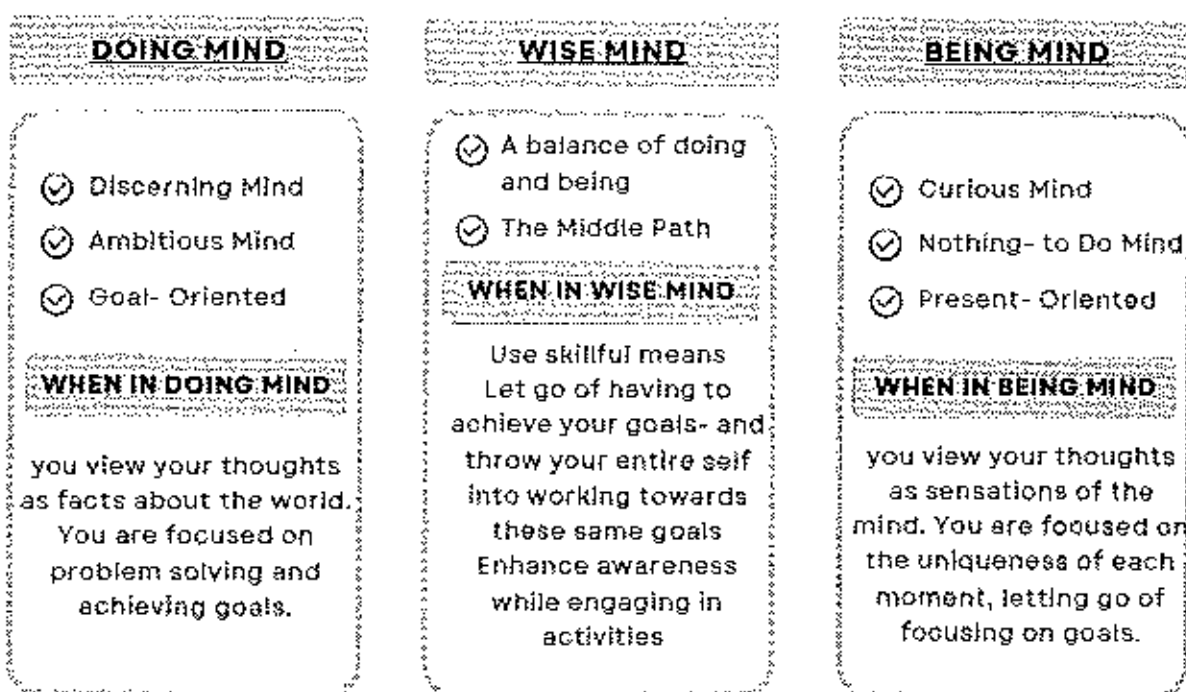


Balancing Doing Mind and Being Mind



Skillful Means

- Each person has the capacity for skillful means. "Skillful Means" is a term in Zen; it refers to any effective method that aids a person to experience reality as it is, or, in DBT terms, to enter fully into Wise Mind.

Doing Mind and Being Mind

- "Doing mind" and "being mind" are states of mind that in their extremes can get in the way of skillful means and of Wise Mind.
- **Doing Mind** focuses on achieving goals
- **Being Mind** focuses on experiencing
- The polarity between them is similar to that between reasonable mind and emotion mind.

The Need for Both Doing Mind and Being Mind

- Without aspects of both Being Mind and Doing Mind, it is difficult, if not impossible, to lead a balanced life.
- Once we let go of balance and, instead, live at one extreme or the other, we start seeing reality from that extreme perspective. We then become biased, and experiencing reality as it is becomes elusive.

Doing Mind

Doing Mind Focuses on Achieving Goals and Doing What Is Needed

- When you are in Doing Mind, similar to Reasonable Mind, you view thoughts as facts about the world. You are comparing where you are now to where you want to be in the future.
- You compare your own behavior and that of others now and in the past to what you want it to be.
- In its extreme form, Doing Mind is relentlessly task focused, climbing to the top with ambition. At this extreme, Doing Mind is driven mind.
- Doing Mind is necessary for getting work done, for meeting goals, for planning, and for evaluating whether we are living our lives according to our values. Processing incoming information and using the information to help us achieve both immediate and long-range goals is clearly important.

Too Little Doing Mind Can Interfere with Achieving Important Goals

- Deficits in doing activities can be destructive. This is particularly true for those individuals who spend many of their waking moments “zoning out,” sleeping, or living lives of leisure or lethargy that ignore their very real needs. Many individuals resort to drugs in order to mobilize themselves to work toward goals. Cocaine, amphetamines, and high levels of caffeine, for example, are used by many to produce an artificial state of doing mind.

Too Much Doing Mind Can Become an Automatic Mode of Being

When we spend too much time in doing mind, we start living our lives on automatic pilot. We act out of habit and do not notice when the situation or context has changed and something else is needed. It can be very easy to make both little and big mistakes.

- ***Problems with doing occur when we become addicted to “doing.”*** Workaholics are caught in doing mind. They work excessively, caught in always doing something. They feel an intense drive to always be doing something productive and, alas, they do not enjoy work. We could call them “doing-aholics.” Perfectionists are also caught in doing mind.
- ***In doing mind, we lose sight of the value of the present moment,*** because we look at the present and the past in terms of how close or far we are from some future goal. We are immersed in activity, losing sight of all else happening around us, like a workaholic who never stops to smell the roses.

Being Mind



Being Mind Is "Beginners' Mind": In being mind, you are open and curious about the moment you are in. Thoughts are viewed as sensations of the mind, arising and falling, coming and going. You are focused on immediate, moment-to-moment experiencing with an open mind; you accept that each moment is as it is. You let go of evaluating the past and the present. There is only 'just this moment.' In its extreme form, being mind focuses on immediate, moment-to-moment experiencing, with no thought of goals or of consequences of current action or absence of action.

Too Little Being Mind Can Interfere with Living Life to Its Fullest

Being mind is "nothing-to-do, nowhere-to-go" mind. When there is nothing to do and nowhere to go, being mind is the place to be. Being mind is the path to spacious mind, to awareness or our connection to the entire universe—the floor that touches our feet and the furthest star in the universe. Being mind is like lying in the grass on a warm sunny day, head in your arms, lotion on your body, just feeling the warm sun beating down. Or it is like lying on your back on a cool summer evening, gazing at the sky and watching the stars. It is watching the clouds going by. Or it is simply attending to a touch on the arm or a smile from someone you know."

Being mind is being present to one's life. Many people find at some point that they have missed a lot of their own lives. Almost always, this is a very sad realization. It is like having a garden full of beautiful roses but never stopping to smell them. Appreciating life requires experiencing life.

Deficits in being mind can be as destructive as deficits in doing mind.

Generally, a deficit in being shows up as an excess of doing: Individuals spend many of their waking moments comparing themselves to others, or comparing their progress in life now to what they expected it to be or wanted it to be. Many individuals find these incessant comparisons so difficult that they try to escape with drugs. Opiates in particular bring about a state of artificial being mind that provides an escape from the anxiety and shame that doing mind run amuck can sometimes create.

Too Much Being Mind Can Be Indulgent and Self-Centered

An excess of being mind can be focused on personal experience at the expense of others and their needs, and of what needs to be done in the moment. Say to participants: "When this happens, being mind can be destructive if there is something that needs to be done or somewhere you need to go. Sitting in meditation, lying around on the beach, or watching the clouds go by is all well and good. But it won't do when you are driving somewhere and need to follow a map; when you have a weekly budget and need to plan, buy, and cook meals for the week; when homework needs to be done; or when e-mail needs to be answered."

Example: Someone who just sits on the couch meditating all day never gets any work done and is stuck in being mind. 'Now, now, now' can interfere with planning for the future for yourself and for those you love and/or are responsible for.